How to identify hate speech and racist narratives

They are not always easy to recognise

When we think of racism or hate speech, we may imagine a direct insult, a threat or an openly racist expression.

But they do not always appear in this form.

They can also appear as a news story, a meme, a video, a statistic, a comment on social media or a claim that seems like “common sense”.

Expressions such as:

- “They take our jobs.”
- “They live off benefits.”

They are not always easy to recognise

- “They make our neighbourhoods unsafe.”

- “They do not want to integrate.”

may seem like individual opinions. But when repeated again and again, they help build a particular image of migrants.

That is why, in this toolkit, we do not only want to look at what a message says.

We also want to ask:

Who does it target?

Does it generalise?

They are not always easy to recognise

What emotions does it try to provoke?

What information does it use?

What story is it constructing about these people?

First: these are not all the same thing

Before continuing, it is important to distinguish some concepts.

A false or misleading rumour

This is false or misleading information that circulates as if it were true.

For example, a post claiming that a public benefit exists exclusively for migrants when that benefit does not exist on those terms.

A false rumour can contain racist content, but not all false rumours are racist.

A stereotype

This is an oversimplified idea that attributes the same characteristics to an entire group.

For example:

“Migrants do not want to integrate.”

People differ from one another. When we turn millions of people into a homogeneous group, we stop seeing their individual histories, circumstances and decisions.

A racist narrative

This goes beyond a single sentence.

It is a way of explaining reality that presents particular racialised groups or people of migrant origin as inferior, problematic, dangerous or less deserving of rights.

A narrative is constructed by repeating ideas, images, words and associations.

That is why it can continue to operate even when nobody uses an explicitly racist insult.

Hate speech

There is no single universal legal definition of hate speech. As a reference, the United Nations describes it as communication, whether spoken, written, visual or expressed through behaviour, that attacks or uses derogatory or discriminatory language against a person or group because of who they are, for example their origin, nationality, race, religion, gender or other identity factors.

Not every criticism, offensive opinion or piece of false information is therefore automatically hate speech.

The context and the way a group is targeted matter.

Five signs that can alert us

SIGN 1. It turns a group into “the problem”

Ask yourself:

Who is presented as responsible?

A message may discuss housing, jobs, safety, public services or living together.

The warning sign appears when complex social problems always end up having the same people to blame:

migrants, undocumented people, Muslim people, Black people, Roma people or other minoritised groups.

The problem stops being a specific situation and

SIGN 1. It turns a group into “the problem”

becomes who these people are.

SIGN 2. It constructs an “us” against a “them”

Pay attention to expressions such as:

- “People from here...”
- “Those people...”
- “Our own people first...”
- “We pay and they receive...”

These phrases construct a symbolic boundary.

There is an “us”, who supposedly belongs, and a “them”, who is portrayed as an outsider, even when those people live, work, study, have families and build community in the same place.

SIGN 2. It constructs an “us” against a “them”

Ask yourself:

Who can belong to the “us” in this message, and who is left out?

SIGN 3. It generalises

Imagine that a person commits a crime.

A news story highlights their origin.

The post is shared thousands of times.

Other similar cases again highlight the same origin.

Gradually, an association can be constructed:

a person of a particular origin is associated with crime.

But one person's behaviour does not allow us to explain the behaviour of an entire group.

We can therefore ask:

SIGN 3. It generalises

If this person were not a migrant or racialised, would their origin be equally important to explaining the news story?

And a second question:

Are we discussing a specific person, or is the message holding an entire group responsible?

SIGN 4. It uses fear

Fear is a very powerful tool.

Some messages present migrants as a threat:

- to jobs;
- to safety;
- to public services;
- to culture;
- to identity.

This does not mean that every debate about employment, safety or public services is racist.

The question is different:

SIGN 4. It uses fear

Are there data and context, or is a group being used to explain a complex problem?

When a post immediately makes us feel fear, anger, indignation or rejection, we have another reason not to share it automatically.

PAUSE.

We will check afterwards.

SIGN 5. It dehumanises

This is one of the signs that should concern us most.

It happens when we stop speaking about people and start speaking about them as a mass or a threat.

Words and metaphors such as:

- “invasion”;
- “avalanche”;
- “wave”

can turn people with different histories into a phenomenon that seems threatening.

Ask yourself:

SIGN 5. It dehumanises

Does this message allow me to see people, or does it only present a mass?

Dehumanisation creates distance. When we stop seeing another person as someone with a history, a family, rights and plans for their life, it becomes easier to accept treating them differently.

UNESCO emphasises that hate speech can target people for who they are and contribute to dehumanisation, intolerance and social division.

Narratives are built through repetition

An isolated phrase does not explain an entire narrative.

But imagine seeing, over several months:

- a news story associating migration with crime;
- a video about migrants and social benefits;
- a politician speaking of an “invasion”;
- a meme about foreign people who “do not want to work”;
- a comment claiming that “they do not want to integrate”.

Narratives are built through repetition

Each piece may seem independent.

But together, they can construct the same story:

“These people are a threat.”

This matters because disinformation does not only work by inventing data.

It can also work by selecting what we explain, what we repeat, what we leave out and which images we constantly associate with particular groups.

Educational materials are not neutral either: UNESCO warns that they can reproduce prejudices, stereotypes and particular views of the social order,

Narratives are built through repetition

which is why it recommends learning to identify these representations.

What if the information is true?

This is an important question.

Information can contain a true fact and still be explained in a way that leads us to a misleading conclusion.

We can ask:

Where does the data come from?

What period does it cover?

What is it being compared with?

What information is missing?

Why is people's origin highlighted?

What if the information is true?

Is a particular case being used to talk about an entire group?

Are we listening to the people the information discusses?

That is why AntiFake does not only ask:

“Is it true or false?”

It also asks:

“Do we have all the information we need to understand what is happening?”

A first AntiFake exercise

When you find a post about migration that provokes a strong reaction, do not yet try to prove whether it is true or false.

First, observe it.

LOOK

1. Who publishes it?

A person? A media outlet? A political party? An anonymous account?

2. Who is it about?

Does it concern a specific person or an entire group?

3. What words does it use?

Does it describe, generalise, ridicule, criminalise or dehumanise?

4. What emotion does it provoke in you?

Fear? Anger? Indignation? Rejection?

LOOK

5. What story is it constructing?

Are people shown as people with rights and their own voices, or only as a problem?

6. What might be left out?

Is there context you would need before reaching a conclusion?

We have not verified anything yet.

We will do that in the next chapter.

Because after PAUSING and LOOKING, it is time to:

CHECK.

LOOK

How do we know whether what we are seeing is true?